

Whisky: Scotland's Water of Life - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

Whisky: Scotland's Water of Life

Every country has a national drink, but few have woven theirs so completely into their identity as Scotland has with whisky. The word itself tells you how seriously they take it. It comes from the Gaelic uisge beatha, which means, quite literally, the water of life. That in turn is a translation of an older Latin phrase, aqua vitae, the name medieval monks gave to any distilled spirit. Over the centuries uisge beatha was worn down by everyday speech, from uisge to usky to, at last, whisky. So the next time someone hands you a dram, remember that you are being offered a small glass of the water of life.

And it is, in a real sense, a taste of the land itself. Scotch whisky is made from just three things: barley, water, and yeast. Yet into it goes the whole character of a place. The water that ran off a particular hillside. The barley grown in a particular field. Sometimes the smoke of peat, the dark spongy turf dug from the bogs, which gives certain whiskies their unmistakable bonfire tang. And always the oak of the cask, where the raw spirit sleeps for years, drawing colour and sweetness out of the wood. A good whisky is a place you can drink.

Over the next few chapters we will follow the whole story. How whisky is actually made, from a field of barley to a glass by the fire. Why a whisky from one corner of Scotland tastes so unlike another. The wild history of smugglers and taxmen and hidden stills in the glens. And, for the grown-ups, where to find a proper dram here in Edinburgh, a city that has always lived close to the trade. Slàinte, as they say here. To your health.

From Barley to Glass

Making whisky is a slow trick played on a field of barley, and it runs in five stages. It begins with malting. The barley is soaked in water and fooled into thinking spring has come, so it starts to sprout, which unlocks the sugars sleeping inside each grain. At exactly the right moment the maltster halts the growth by drying the grain with heat. And here is the first great fork in the road. In some places, above all the island of Islay, that drying is done over a fire of peat, the dark ancient turf cut from the bogs, and the smoke sinks deep into the grain. That is where a smoky whisky gets its smoke, decided right at the start, in the kiln.

Next comes mashing. The dried malt is ground and stirred into hot water in a great vat, and out runs a warm, sweet liquid, almost a thin unhopped beer, called the wort. Then fermenting. The wort goes into huge wooden or steel washbacks, yeast is thrown in, and for a couple of days the whole thing froths and hisses and roars as the yeast eats the sugar and turns it to alcohol. What you have now is a rough, sour beer of about eight percent, called the wash.

Then the heart of it. The wash is boiled in those beautiful onion-shaped copper stills, some of them fifteen or twenty feet tall, gleaming and dented. Alcohol boils before water does, so it rises first as a vapour, travels up the swan neck of the still, and is caught and cooled back into a liquid far stronger than before. Scotch is usually distilled twice, in two different stills, each pass leaving the spirit cleaner and stronger.

The stillman has to judge exactly which part of the run to keep, the pure “heart,” and throw the rest back to be run again. It is a knack learned over years, by nose as much as by instrument.

And then the longest stage of all. Waiting. The clear, fiery new spirit is filled into oak casks, very often old barrels that once held sherry or American bourbon, and rolled into a dark warehouse to sleep. By law it must rest at least three years before it can even be called Scotch, and the good stuff sleeps for ten, fifteen, twenty years and more. In that quiet the harsh spirit mellows, turns gold, and drinks colour and flavour out of the wood. All the while a little escapes through the pores of the oak, roughly two percent a year, gone into the air. The distillers have a fine name for it. They call it the angels’ share, the cut the angels take for guarding the barrels. After a dozen years in the cask the angels may have drunk nearly a quarter of it. That is the price of patience, and you can taste every year of it.

The Science of Whisky

If the making of whisky sounds like magic, it is really chemistry, and rather beautiful chemistry at that. Follow what is actually happening and every step makes plain sense.

Start with fermentation. Yeast is alive, a microbe, and like any living thing it eats and gives off waste. Feed it sugar and it produces two things, alcohol and carbon dioxide, the very gas that fizzes in a fizzy drink. That is the trick behind every alcoholic drink on earth. The sugars from the barley go in, the yeast gets busy, and out come alcohol and a great roaring head of bubbles. Nothing more mysterious than that.

Then distillation, which is only a way of separating things with heat. Alcohol boils at seventy-eight degrees, water at a hundred. So if you warm the fermented liquid gently, the alcohol turns to vapour and rises before most of the water does. Catch that vapour, cool it back to a liquid, and you have pulled the alcohol away from the water, stronger than before. That is all a still is. A copper kettle for catching the right steam.

If it were only alcohol and water, though, it would taste of nothing. The flavour lives in tiny trace compounds that ride along with the alcohol, and distillers call them congeners. Two families matter most. Esters are the fruity, flowery smells, pear and apple and cut grass, made mostly in the still. Phenols are the smoky, medicinal ones, and they come from the peat smoke driven into the barley right at the start. More peat, more phenols, more bonfire. So when you catch fruit or smoke in a glass, you are smelling real molecules with real names.

The great change, though, happens in the barrel, and the hero is oak. Fresh off the still the spirit is clear and harsh. Years in a cask turn it into something else entirely, and the wood does three jobs at once. It gives colour and sweetness, above all where the barrel has been charred, burnt black inside, because that toasted layer breaks down a substance in the wood called lignin and frees vanillin, the same molecule that gives vanilla its scent. It cleans, because that char works like the charcoal in a water filter, quietly pulling out the young spirit’s harsh, sulphury notes. And it breathes, because oak is porous, so a little air seeps in year upon year and softens the whisky, while a little whisky seeps out and drifts off into the air. That escaping share, about two percent a year, is the famous angels’ share.

One last piece of science, the trick every enthusiast swears by. Add a drop of water. It sounds mad, to water down something you have waited twenty years for, but there is hard chemistry behind it. Researchers ran the simulations and found that in strong whisky the flavour molecules, one of them named guaiacol, hide down in the liquid, pinned there by the high alcohol. Add a splash of water, drop the alcohol a touch, and those molecules rise to the surface and leap into the air, straight up your nose. The water does not weaken the whisky. It sets the smells loose.

A Map in a Glass

Here is a thing that delights whisky lovers. You can taste geography. Scotch is divided into five whisky regions, part official line, part old tradition, and each has a character of its own. Learn them, and a glass becomes a map.

The biggest by far is Speyside, gathered around the river Spey in the northeast, where more than half of Scotland's distilleries are crammed together. Speyside malts are the crowd-pleasers, elegant and fruity, apple and pear and honey, sometimes deepened with dried fruit from old sherry casks. Glenfiddich, Glenlivet, Macallan, all Speyside. Next comes the vast sprawling Highland region, which covers most of the map and so covers most of the moods too, from light and floral to big and muscular. The Lowlands, down toward England, tend to be the gentlest, soft and grassy, once nicknamed the breakfast whiskies, which tells you how easy they go down. Campbeltown is the curiosity, a single small town on a far western peninsula that once held over thirty distilleries and now keeps just a precious handful, making a salty, characterful dram all its own.

And then there is Islay. Say it "eye-la." A small windblown island in the west, made largely of peat, and its whiskies are the wild ones, drenched in smoke and sea salt and something almost medicinal, tasting of bonfires and seaweed and, some swear, hospital antiseptic, in the best possible way. People who love Islay love it fiercely. People meeting it for the first time sometimes wonder if their drink is on fire. Both reactions are correct.

One more distinction is worth knowing, because you will see it on every bottle. A single malt is the whisky of one single distillery, made only from malted barley. The proud individual. A blend, like Johnnie Walker or Famous Grouse, is a marriage of many whiskies from many distilleries, married for a smooth and steady taste, and it was blends that conquered the world. Neither is better than the other. One is a soloist. The other is a choir.

So how does a grown-up actually taste the stuff? Slowly, and with a bit of respect. You pour a small measure, a dram, into a glass that narrows at the top to gather the aromas. First you just smell it, nosing it gently, because most of what we call taste is really smell. Then a small sip, rolled around the mouth. And here is the trick the experts swear by. Add a drop or two of water. It sounds like heresy, but a little water opens the whisky up, releases hidden aromas, and softens the sting of the alcohol. Smell it again and it is a different drink. That is the whole pleasure of it. Not to drink much, but to notice much.

Scotch, Irish, and the World's Whiskies

Scotch is not the only whisky in the world, only the most famous. Once you notice the family, you start to spot the cousins everywhere. They share one idea, grain fermented and distilled and aged in wood, but each country bends the recipe its own way, and you can taste who did what.

Start at home. Scotch is made chiefly from malted barley, usually distilled twice, sometimes touched with peat smoke, and the law says it must sit in oak casks in Scotland for at least three years before anyone may call it Scotch. Look at the spelling, too. In Scotland there is no letter e. It is whisky.

Cross to Ireland and an e appears. Irish whiskey is usually distilled three times instead of twice, and that extra pass sands off more of the rough edges, so the classic Irish style is smooth and light and honeyed rather than smoky. Peat is rare there. The story goes that Irish distillers added the e in the eighteen hundreds to set their bottles apart from Scotch, and the habit stuck. Irish immigrants carried the spelling across the Atlantic, which is why America writes whiskey too.

American whiskey is a different creature, and the difference is the grain and the wood. Bourbon, from Kentucky and beyond, is made mostly from corn, which gives it a broad sweetness, and it must be aged in brand-new oak barrels that have been charred, burnt black on the inside. That fresh scorched wood

floods it with vanilla and caramel and coconut, which is why bourbon tastes so round and sweet beside a Scotch. And here is the lovely link back to Scotland. Once an American barrel has held bourbon, the law forbids using it for bourbon again, so it is shipped off to Scotland and filled with Scotch. A great deal of Scotch grows up in second-hand bourbon barrels. Rye whiskey is bourbon's sharper sibling, made mostly from rye grain, all pepper and spice.

Then there is Japan, the newcomer that startled everybody. A century ago a Japanese distiller came to Scotland, learned the craft properly, went home and built distilleries that copied the Scottish way almost line for line, down to the shape of the stills. The Japanese spell it whisky, no e, out of respect for the teacher. For decades the world paid no attention. Then Japanese bottles began winning the top prizes on earth, and now they stand among the finest made anywhere, priced to match.

So the label gives you a clue before you taste a drop. Scotland, Japan and Canada write whisky. Ireland and the United States write whiskey. One letter, and behind it the whole tangled history of who learned from whom.

Smugglers, Excisemen and the World

The written story of Scotch begins with a single line in the royal account books. In fourteen ninety-four, a clerk of King James the Fourth noted a delivery of malt "to Friar John Cor, to make aqua vitae." Eight bolls of it, a great heap of grain, enough by some reckonings for well over a thousand bottles. So the first named whisky-maker in history is a monk, in an abbey in Fife, and by fourteen ninety-four he plainly already knew his business, which means the craft was older still. That is where the paper trail starts. The real story runs back into the mist behind it, and nobody knows who made the first drop.

For a long time whisky was just something Scots made, on farms, in cottages, a handy way to turn a wet barley harvest into something that kept and warmed and could be sold or bartered. Then the government worked out it could be taxed, and everything changed. The duty on spirits climbed, and whisky-making dived underground, quite literally. Thousands of illegal stills were tucked into the glens, in caves and barns and heather, their smoke passed off as morning mist, the whisky carried out under cover of dark. In the early eighteenth century the authorities were seizing something like fourteen thousand illegal stills a year, and it was reckoned that more than half the whisky drunk in Scotland had never paid a penny of tax.

Against the smugglers stood the excisemen, the taxmen, known in Scotland as gaugers because they gauged, or measured, the barrels to work out the duty owed. They were the most hated men in the glens. And here is one of the great ironies of Scottish history. The nation's beloved poet, Robert Burns, spent his last years as one of them. Burns, the man who wrote Auld Lang Syne, needed a steady wage to feed his family, and from seventeen eighty-nine until his death in seventeen ninety-six he rode the roads around Dumfries as an exciseman, measuring whisky for the taxman by day and, one suspects, drinking cheerfully with the smugglers by night. He even dashed off a merry poem about the Devil carrying the exciseman away, to everyone's delight.

The turning point came in eighteen twenty-three. A new law, the Excise Act, slashed the duty and made it possible, for the first time, to distil legally without being ruined. One by one the smugglers came in from the cold and took out licences. A farmer named George Smith, at Glenlivet, was among the very first, and so unpopular with his old smuggling neighbours for going straight that he carried a pair of pistols for years. Out of that new legal trade, and above all out of the clever art of blending, Scotch grew from a Highland secret into one of the world's great drinks, shipped from Leith, the port just down the hill from where you stand, to every corner of the Empire and beyond. Edinburgh, with its harbours and its merchants and its blenders, sat right at the centre of it. The water of life had gone off to conquer the world.

Where to Find a Dram in Edinburgh

So, having heard the whole story, where does a curious grown-up actually go to taste it? Edinburgh is spoiled for choice, and the good news is you need not be an expert. You need only be willing.

The classic is probably the Bow Bar, on steep and colourful Victoria Street just below the castle. It looks as though it has stood there forever, a snug traditional room with no music and no fuss, and behind the bar rises a magnificent tall wooden gantry, said to have been rescued from an old church, lined with more than three hundred whiskies. They do proper Scotch pies too, so you can eat while you dither. If you fancy something a little more polished, walk up to the Whiski Rooms near the top of the Mound, almost in the shadow of the castle, a smart bar and restaurant with a shop attached, where they run friendly tutored tastings and will happily marry a dram to food, or to cheese, or to chocolate.

For the true enthusiast there is the Topsy Midgie, a tiny, cosy den that was named Scotland's best whisky bar two years running, in twenty twenty-three and again in twenty twenty-four, with getting on for a thousand bottles crammed behind its little bar and a team who love nothing better than steering you toward something new. And for a bit of theatre, hunt down Usquabae, whose name is simply the old Gaelic for water of life, a dark and handsome cellar bar down in the vaults with four hundred whiskies and snug private booths where you can settle in for the evening.

One important word for anyone new to this. Do not start with the smoky monsters of Islay, or you may never come back. Begin with something gentle and fruity, a Speyside perhaps, and ask the bartender, who will be glad you did. Take it slowly. Add a drop of water. Smell before you sip. A dram is not a thing to knock back but a thing to sit with.

And if the whole family is together, one place welcomes everyone, up on Castlehill by the castle. The Scotch Whisky Experience. It is built for curious visitors of every age, with a gentle barrel ride through the making of whisky and the astonishing Diageo Claive Vidiz collection, the largest gathering of Scotch whisky in the world, well over three thousand bottles glowing on the shelves like jewels. The children get the ride and the smells and the wide-eyed wonder. Afterwards, the grown-ups can slip off to one of those bars and raise a well-earned glass. Slàinte mhath. Good health.